
Politics behind the Score: The Institutionalization of the São Paulo Municipal Symphony Orchestra

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Abstract

The São Paulo Municipal Symphony Orchestra (OSM) was institutionalized by law in 1949. The institutionalization process took place throughout the entire year and involved numerous agents. Musicians, councilors and even the mayor were the main actors noted in the City Councils Minutes on which this research is based. The following paper aims to uncover political issues such as "why should an orchestra be institutionalized in a legal form" and "whose interests were involved in the process' cause".

By examining the City Council's Minutes from 1949, the research reached a total of 25 sessions in which the process of institutionalizing the Orchestra was under discussion. Through the source it was possible to see not just how many councilors were involved (24) but the degree to which they engaged in the debates by speeches, votes and arguments. Each session brings a perspective on what that "past present" (Koselleck) constructed policy of memory: what discussions should be transcribed, which gestures should be registered, whose absences were noticed and which decisions should be remembered.

Social Network Analysis is employed as a digital method to identify and question patterns of interaction, alignment, and disagreement that are not immediately visible through close reading alone. Rather than claiming to reveal historical "truth," the method enhances visualization by working on data created through interpretive decisions grounded in the sources (Torgerson, 2022). Focusing on musical cultural heritage, this approach results in an interdisciplinary framework conceived as a polyphonic analysis, in which multiple voices, perspectives, and forms of expertise coexist within the network (Tang and Wu 2025). This model is proposed as a productive way to analyze music institutions.

The main outcomes of the visualizations are: i) members of the same political party did not always vote in the same way, indicating relative autonomy in supporting the bill; ii) councilors held different views on how institutionalization should take place; and iii) musicians appeared as technical specialists, but their opinions were not dominant in the legislative process.

References

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